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Solar light nearly twice his size. He cleaved through the last monster with surgical precision, melting the monster into the beam beneath it.

The chamber lurched, a violent tilt to the side. Well Five was failing and failing fast. The T.E.B. scrambled in, trying to reach the control panels, but shockwaves from the breached Well threw them back against the walls.

“What do we do?” King shouted into his cometech.

A voice crackled through their comtechs, flickering wildly, making the words hard to hear. “We... rig a containment gate,” a young Echelon tech shouted, his voice trembling. “But... too wide... a full energy... harness... hold.”

“We don’t have one,” Darius snarled, already forming a molten shield to protect them from the erratic energy flashes. King shoved himself behind it and started walking towards the Well. “Get to the Well. We will place what we can.” Eira slid to the back of the tunnel, grabbing the containment harnesses from an Echelon tech. Nyx took one from her and they both squeezed in behind Darius and King, pushing forward to the Well.

The closer they got, the more gravity condensed around them, the weight of the planet pressing down on them. Nyx felt her nose begin to bleed and saw that Eira’s ears were dripping blood, while Darius and King both had significant nosebleeds.

The heat was so intense at the base of the Well that the Magma wall began to melt, so Darius let it burn down enough to let them work.

The breaches were wide and irregular; the harness, not having any surface to attach to, couldn’t span the entire Well.

Eira looked to King helplessly, blood sputtering from her lips.

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“Fall back!” he gritted out. Eira fell back in a flurry of snow, catching herself in a soft bluff against the back. Darius turned to try again, but King grabbed him by the shoulder. “We need to go!” They tumbled back, unable to keep their ground against King’s sudden movements.

Nyx looked down at the harness she was holding, the sound of screams still echoing in her mind. She started absorbing the harnesses into her body, burning every part in her mind, her hands shaking violently. If she failed, then they would all die.

Her skin was peeling and she felt the heat sear her face. She screamed as memories, heat, and light flooded her senses. She pushed herself closer, wrapping her arms as wide as she could around the Well, the pain screaming through her body, and then—nothing.

She was in a garden with the same blonde boy she had remembered earlier. She was happy and laughing. “Oh, Thallion the Scallion!” she teased, throwing flowers at him. They were together in a field of strange, beautiful beasts. And they were wild and free. A home she couldn’t name, a family? Flashes of an old man writing notes in a classroom, his back to her. Her and Thallion giggling and drawing caricatures of him on their desks.

The memories tore away back to the Well, her face streaming and sizzling with blood and energy. The last strands of the harness fused around the Well, swallowing and stabilising the energy and heat around her. Her fingers slipped and she let go, falling backwards as the ceiling spun, the lights red and bloodied.

Then darkness.

Chapter 24

Vexal's eye burned as it flickered open, his mind temporarily confused before realising they weren't at the Big O. The ceiling above him was a smooth alloy, freshly welded, and a deep, rich hum rumbled beneath him. His eye darted around the room, finally settling on Lyra, who was curled in a small chair beside him, a damp compress hanging loosely from her fingers.

They were at the new safehouse in the Reactor Six ruins. He had just started moving his gear and some supporters here when Fane had burst in. The thought brought a responding ache in his ribs; he sat up slowly, the motion tearing a groan from his throat.

Lyra jerked awake and rushed to him. "Vexal," she breathed, her wiry arms steadying him. Her eyes were rimmed red and she looked exhausted.

"How long was I out?" he asked, his voice dry and raspy.

"Not long; the twelfth hour hasn't even come yet," she said, relief in her voice.

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Fragments of memories hit him like slow knives in his soul. Fane crushing his bones, cutting open his body, and brutalising him. Myth's hands on his body, the sting of her powers threading through his veins even though he had begged her not to. He stopped himself, forcing the memories deep into the back of his mind. He refused to think about any of it right now.

A distant boom shuddered through the walls. He swung his legs off the cot, ignoring the pull of fresh scars, and limped toward the bank of monitors on the far side of the room. R6 groaned softly around them, humming with low energy supplied by the Ash King AI, his face blinking through several screens, monitoring and watching.

Vexal looked at the outside monitors, distorted by snow and ice; it seemed like the weather outside had gotten worse. He exhaled slowly. The cold and ice had slowed his bleeding enough to let him get to the Big O, barely.

Lyra's voice broke through his thoughts. "We came here because Fane has done something. Something horrible." Her words came out in a rush. "The Apex Corps tried to stop it, but it was too close for comfort, so I moved us before... Well, I don't know what happened except part of the Undercity floor collapsed. Now the whole zone's crawling with patrols."

Vexal turned and nodded grimly, his blood running cold as he pieced together what had happened. "Did everyone make it here?"

"Everyone but Myth. She had gotten called in, I'm assuming for this very threat," she said with a strange tightness in her voice.

He only nodded and strode out to the main chamber, Lyra following close on his heels. Soft cheers and gasps of relief spread through the hundreds of people filling the refitted reactor. Dregs, Echelons, and even a few scattered Luminals, their faces turned toward him, desperate for leadership and answers. He climbed onto a makeshift platform and let the silence hang

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momentarily. “Today,” he said, his voice still scratchy but strong, “is the day we stop hiding in the shadows.”

The crowd roiled; scattered hoots and claps echoed before they were hushed, waiting.

“Fane Dryst has attacked the very foundation of Titan itself. The AAN will retaliate indiscriminately, looking for someone to blame. But we will not be their scapegoats. No more crawling and hiding in the shadows; no more making sure we are not seen or heard. We will stand alongside every other person as equals on this planet. We are the *Ash Blight Rebellion*.”

The chamber erupted in cheers, and fists and energy were shot into the air in celebration. Vexal let them celebrate, and when all was quiet again, he began to outline the command structure. The Ash King AI was going to handle all logistics and comms; Korric would build the strike units and secure weapons; Lyra had already organised supply runs, shelters, and field care for families that were directly affected by the damage caused by the Apexes' heroics.

As the members went to their respective missions, he slipped away, back through the narrow corridor to his quarters, shutting the din out behind him. He drew a long breath, steadying himself before pinging Myth through his comtech. There was no answer and the signal stuttered oddly, so he killed it, his gut twisting slightly.

He distracted his thoughts by preparing a prosthetic eye from a tray and attached it carefully, savouring the pain as the lens booted up, syncing to his comtech and monitors. He blinked slowly, his eyes finally clear and seeing equally again. He sighed heavily. Grabbing his coat, he went to go find the AI. He needed info, and that slimy virus was in everything.

The Ash King AI was in a central hub in the reactor, his humanoid frame draped in torn white velvet and odd gold drapings, with endless lines of manic code instead of pupils.

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“Aaah! Ahah! Vexal Kaine Ophedius! The Rot Saint!” the AI said in an overly cheery voice.

Vexal gave him a look, fighting his annoyance.

“Ah, well, what can I do for you?” The AI hummed and coughed slightly.

“Information. And I want details,” Vexal said flatly.

The AI spun around, servos humming, the many screens around them syncing into a solid picture. “Well then, my dread prince, see Sector Zero. One of Titan’s highest-security zones, and right now it’s on full T.E.B. lockdown. Fane Dryst let loose his little pets here,” He pointed with a slim mechanical finger, “and here’s where they turned up, destroying infrastructure all the way to here, Catalyst Well Three and Five.” The AI turned again, screens flashing in sequence. “But here’s the real twist!” The AI pointed its mechanical arm in manic grace. Myth was standing blood-streaked and exhausted, while Darius Valkyrie and Helios King wrestled with a massive beast of some sort. The collapsing Well behind them seemed to be their point of contention. Vexal leaned forward, eyes narrowing, the feed flickering and fuzzing wildly from the energy fluctuations.

“They weren’t Dregs!” the AI squealed excitedly. “They were bio-fusions! Human core matter spliced with and shaped by recycled reactor and Catalyst metals! It’s a miracle they lived long enough to even get that far, and they went right for the strongest energy source!” The AI grinned, glass teeth catching the light. “Lucky for us.”

Vexal shot him a look. “How is this good for us?”

The AI laughed, a warped, echoing sound. “Oh, my grouchy friend, it keeps the Apexes busy! Once they announce to the populace that there’s a new monster abroad and Fane Dryst is on the loose, they will have their hands full! Leaving us to topple their gods and right the world!”

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Vexal didn't say anything, and the AI tapped another screen. The footage replayed Myth alone against the reactor, holding it together and fusing a containment net of some sort around it before collapsing. Vexal's jaw tightened.

"Don't worry, she's alive," the AI said in a chipper voice. "Barely. But she's got the best doctors on the planet at her beck and call, so she'll be fine!"

Vexal turned, changing the subject abruptly. "Recruit count?"

The AI jumped, delighted at the question, displaying a large roster of names and counts in place of the footage. "We have our main host here, around one hundred and eighty. They represent millions of lower Echelons, Dregs, and even a few Apexes, and they are all here to officially start the movement."

"Good." Vexal straightened, his voice hard. "We need order and communication. You will coordinate the network, make our own lines. I'll take the field units."

The Ash King bowed theatrically. "As you decree, my stormy-eyed sovereign."

Vexal ignored the title, already turning away, his thoughts sharpening. He needed to prepare for Fane's next move, but it was hard to predict chaos-wrapped insanity. His destruction always came in waves, and the man's mind was anything but linear.

He had chosen a reactor because of its resistance to corrosion, bu—

Every comtech in the chamber suddenly lit up, a shrill tone echoing throughout, sending a stab of pain through his ears. An emergency live broadcast, AAN-sealed and no way to block it. It was on anything and everything with a screen or voice. The feed on his comtech blinked in: General Voxx standing rigid at attention behind High Chancellor Mereen, her face drawn and serious.

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“Today marks a day of mourning,” she began, her cold, clear voice ringing across every device in a short echo. “Today, the Dregs we so mercifully allowed to live among us struck us at our very heart. Our lifeblood was targeted in an act of **terror**.”

The screen split, showing reel after reel of horror. The fused living nightmare of flesh trying to consume the Catalyst Well; Myth lying broken in a pool of her own blood with Eira Solaris cradling her; splashes of acid and blood painting a gruesome picture. Innocent citizens were seen falling from support beams and being crushed under ruined homes.

“Our heroes fought bravely,” she continued. “But enough is enough. Fane Solomon Dryst, leader of these abominations, has declared open war on Titan.” The screen showed a long-outdated picture of Fane before returning to a very serious Chancellor. “We will not let this threat go quietly. And we will not tolerate this festering infection of violence and weakness. We begin today by opening Apex recruitment to all Echelon and Luminial classes. There will be no free passes, but a minimum cycle year’s pass rate of eighty percent is now in effect. We will forge an army and we will emerge from this stronger than ever. We will fight and we will purge these monsters!” She saluted sharply. “We are Titan.”

A roar of applause followed, then the screen flickered dead. Crushing silence radiated throughout the reactor; only the soft hum of the energy generators could be heard.

Vexal’s mind was racing. They rallied and divided, reframing how Dregs would even be viewed. He raised his comtech. “Lyra. Get Korric.”

He turned sharply back to the panicking AI.

“I had no idea!” the AI stammered, its humanoid hands flailing. “Clearly those weren’t Dregs! I mean, anyone can see that! The AAN just wanted an excuse to—”

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“**Shut. Up.**” Vexal bit out. He jabbed a finger toward the console. “Send out a bulletin to every member, every sympathiser, every open channel you can. Those were not Dregs and people deserve to know the truth. And it will come from us, the Ash Blight Rebellion. She called us monsters on purpose, so when they start to purge us, no one will bat an eye.”

Heavy footsteps echoed behind him, and he felt Korric's large hand on his shoulder for a brief moment before the massive man took his place beside him. Lyra phased through the main terminal, causing the AI to squeak and scramble aside.

“It’s worse than that,” she said grimly. “They’re already blaming Dregs for the structural damage and the crime spikes, not just in the Undercity, but all over Titan.”

He nodded grimly, the weight of all the decisions weighing on him. “Lyra, Korric. We are going to need enhancements and weapons. We need specialty-grade weapons and not a lot of time to get them.”

“I have already targeted a few areas and we have two old Tech Enforcers to help,” Korric said.

Vexal nodded. “Our next step will be proving we are a separate force, peaceful unless provoked. It is pivotal we use this time wisely. If we don’t—” He didn’t finish his sentence. He didn’t need to. They had no choice now but to stand their ground and fight back.

Chapter 25

Rhea Vaelith was officially panicking. Commander Voxx was breathing down her neck, waiting for her report, the full force of the AAN's top brass was waiting for results, and every monitor in the diagnostics bay was blinking red. No results, just failure on eerie readouts while the medtechs couldn't even get proper scans, let alone pull viable metrics.

Nyx had collapsed from exhaustion in Sector Zero and had been brought in immediately. After they hooked her up to the system, her energy had triggered a major surge, a violent one that had nearly killed Rhea. She had never seen anything like it before, and the readouts were all in the negatives. As if Nyx's body was draining energy from everything nearby. Power tools, the

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arrays, and even people. They had to isolate her before she did too much damage and the techs were literally leeched dry.

She had tried to call Darius twice, but both times he was still on patrol in the Undercity, caught cleaning up the fallout of the latest Dreg rampage. She glanced toward her private bay he usually docked at, her pulse racing, but her bay still stood empty.

She sprinted back to Nyx's containment unit; it was humming unnaturally and every diagnostic line was a jagged branch of static. Another tech came running up, safety gear melted, his face an unhealthy shade of white.

"It's getting worse!" he gasped. "I think we need to move—"

"We wait for Captain Valkyrie!" she snapped, her voice sharp from her rising stress levels. Her emerald skin flushed darker and her energy buzzed uncomfortably over old wounds. She forced herself to breathe; she needed to figure out a plan, and fast.

Suddenly, she felt a blazing pulse of heat behind her, the tech flinching away and heading back down to shed his safety gear and probably get checked out.

"Rhea! I'm here!" Darius stormed down the corridor, his uniform scorched and bloodied, acid still evident on his gauntlets. But his energy signature felt solid and stable, that was good at least.

"She's not responding," she said hurriedly as he stripped his gear. "She's drawing energy from anything and everything, and I thought you might know something about this."

"I can fix this," he said shortly.

Rhea opened her mouth to argue, or at least get more details. But he was already moving into Nyx's containment unit, heat visibly rolling off him. She reached for her console

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instinctively as he strode across the room without hesitation, dropping to his knees beside Nyx's broken frame.

He touched Nyx gently and Rhea nearly screamed as she saw him unleash a blast of Magma energy directly into Nyx. He picked her up gently, cradling her with unusual tenderness, his brow furrowed as if he was bearing the weight of the whole world.

Rhea watched as the metrics lit up across every display and she rushed to her main console, her fingers flying. Her eyes widened as the numbers surged. Darius and Nyx's resonance were synchronising. Rhea shook her head, trying to understand what she was seeing as Darius's output held steady, feeling Nyx's energy in real-time without being overdrawn. Nyx's vitals jumped instantaneously and, from what Rhea could gather, her body was healing. Even Darius's wounds began healing.

When it ended, Nyx slumped peacefully back onto the bed. Her body stabilised and it looked like she fell asleep instantly. Darius backed out carefully before walking out without a word.

Rhea grabbed him by the arm and pulled him into her office, immediately slapping a lock on the chamber door.

"What. Was. That?" she squealed as she pulled up Nyx's room comms. She wanted to make sure nobody disturbed her newfound peace for the moment.

Darius ran his hand through his soot-streaked hair, looking renewed and fresh. "We had a moment during training," he said slowly. "She told me... a little. But everything's been moving so fast, we never got the chance to really... get into it."

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Rhea exhaled through her nose, biting her tongue because she wanted to yell at the giant man. He should have reported it immediately, reported it to her, but yelling was not going to help anything. “I’m building her energy profile,” she said instead, turning to her console. “Tracking her output from today, which started with your incident this morning. She has healed, warped, done who knows what, warped, and then the Sector Zero incident. She honestly shouldn’t even be alive, let alone synergising on this scale.”

Darius shifted uncomfortably. “She’s got support,” he muttered.

“No,” she corrected. “You are her support. And if you’re not there, if you can’t get there in time? What happens then?”

Darius didn’t answer. His molten eyes studied her carefully and she wished she knew what he was thinking. She stood up, frustrated, snapping a resonance band on his bicep, and she noted how it was almost twice the size of her head. “This will buy us some time,” she said, drawing blood steadily. “They’ll want samples and they’re going to want her in containment. But if we study you, her primary energy source, it seems, we can stall.”

Darius nodded, but clearly looked confused.

“You two make an incredible pair. The levels between the two of you are just unheard of, and I have never seen stabilisation like that. The AAN will be beyond hesitant to split you up. And this means she’s not a god; she has limits and is still very mortal.”

Darius nodded again, clearly thinking things over.

“She has got to stop vanishing, though,” Rhea continued, turning back to her desk. “The AAN has eyes and she’s a public figure now. Which means...”

She turned back to him. “If you were bonded, formally, things would change for the better and the normal.”

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His eyes sharpened and he tilted his head.

“If you both bonded, you would be granted additional medical protection. For the most viable possible embryos, they would want you together and unstressed so... at the very least, retirement. Not even the High Chancellor dare raise such a stink at a time like this.”

Darius nodded slowly. “I’ll think about it.”

Rhea nodded with a sigh and released his arm from the resonance band. “You should head back here after your shift. She’ll probably need you and I might have news.”

He nodded and retrieved his gear before stepping toward the open balcony, stopping at the entrance of his transport. “Thank you, Rhea.” His deep voice rumbled across her office. And then he was gone.

She stood alone in her lab, her screens surrounding her in a comforting blue glow. She ran a hand across her eyes and spun toward her desk again. She had to write this report in a way that would not only let her study Nyx, but give Nyx and Darius a chance at something other than permanent containment.

Chapter 26

Varian moved with a painful limp, his thighs and ribs still aching, slowly healing from Vexal's Rot. He limped past rows of biofabricated monsters, hissing and growling softly in their tanks, pulsing with latent violence in their limbs. These weren't Sweetlings anymore, not after what Fane had done to them.

His stomach churned as he felt Fane looming behind him, saying nothing, but watching his every move coldly. His presence pressed in like a weight against Varian's spine, judging him. He hated the feeling of being watched by someone smarter, crueller, and infinitely more unpredictable than the monsters they'd grown.

He adjusted the final gene modulation, his fingers trembling slightly. The last batch was a set of true monstrosities, and Fane was ecstatic. These monsters couldn't target precise locations; they were hardly even sentient. They went straight for the nearest and strongest power source,

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like feral, energy-starved beasts. Fane wanted to destroy as much of Titan as he could, in the shortest time possible.

When he was done, Varian stepped back and gave Fane a stiff nod. Fane said nothing and began checking over his work as if he were already bored. Varian waited until he was waved away to take his leave, trying not to show his limp as he exited the reactor and climbed into his personal transport.

As the craft lifted above the congested cities, the nausea returned in a rush. His mind spun and he resisted the urge to lie down. He had made a deal with Fane for science, power, and scientific breakthroughs people never dreamed were possible. But Fane was truly insane and a ticking time-bomb with no allegiance. Winning a war meant nothing if the whole world was destroyed in the process.

Varian landed with a soft click and he moved as quickly as his bruised frame could allow, hobbling into the crystal heart of the Ascension Council Chambers. The air was thick inside; gilded light refracted across the crystal like gold. At the far end of the chamber sat High Chancellor Mereen, her arms braced against her desk, a young Apex hopeful behind her synergising away quietly and obediently.

“Have you heard from the shadow kid?” she asked loudly, without a preamble.

Varian nodded and hobbled in closer, catching his breath. “Yes, ma’am, Bryn Alaric is in exceptional control of his mutation now. He’s run three deep in-field infiltrations already. You didn’t even see him at the Colosseum!”

Mereen’s thin brow arched; she smiled thinly, her opal-hued body moving back and forth rhythmically. “Perfect. Then it’s time to officially deploy him. The rebellion was an unpleasant

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surprise. We need to know everything about them. Locations, weapons caches, leadership, all of it. Down to the last sympathiser.”

Varian nodded. “It will be done immediately. About the Sweetlings... they...”

“Did *far* more damage than your reports had promised?” she snapped, cutting him off. “I know Fane tricked us. Tricked us all. Played at being weak so he could sneak around essentially free to do whatever he wished behind our backs. Now we’ve got a full-blown war and media disaster on our hands. Increase every mutation programme. I want spikes across all districts so we have enough people to even deal with this mess.”

Varian swallowed hard, slightly relieved he wasn’t being blamed for this. “Yes, ma’am.”

Mereen stood abruptly, waving the young Apex out of the room, her expression flat as she sat at her desk without even putting a robe on. “You know we are on a short, short clock,” she said, clicking through different screens. “Fane has proven his actions are only going to escalate, and we still haven’t secured 001X.”

Varian’s heart fluttered in his chest slightly. “Is the AAN stepping in?” he asked carefully.

“Negative. She doesn’t respond well at all to any kind of force,” Mereen said, shaking her head. “She is too reactionary, and right now I don’t have the manpower or resources on hand to properly handle a temper tantrum. No, I want illusion; I want a clean new fold, no cracks.”

He rubbed his jaw nervously. “We could have Fane approach her.”

Mereen looked up sharply. “Perfect.”

He resisted the urge to smile; Fane’s aggressive nature was sure to push the subject into paranoia. She would have to pick a side, and Mereen and the AAN were sure it would be theirs. They had no idea about Vexal’s ties to her. She was almost sure to go with Vexal, and when she did, he would be there in the wings, quietly waiting to step in.

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“I will see to it as soon as she is back in the field?” he said with a question in his voice.

Mereen frowned, clearly weighing the pros and cons. He decided to give her a small push. “She will make for a good unifying figure with Valkyrie. And he will be sure to keep her in line and available.”

Mereen finally nodded, standing and waving a hand toward the door. “She’s going to change the course of Titan,” the Chancellor said as Varian saluted shortly and turned to leave. “And you are going to be there to make sure.”

Varian smiled to himself, the doors closing behind him in a clang of polished crystal, as he limped to his private chambers deep within the marrow of Helion’s Tree Spire, to his own private sanctum. As he drew closer, the corridors grew quieter and the lush super-light was replaced with the soft hums of sterile walls and pale lights. His office was vast, cold, and windowless. Rows of projections blinked in resonance-blue liquid, each humming a soft electronic lullaby.

He eased into his chair with a groan, the tension in his spine unrelenting. The last day still burned in his mind. Vexal’s bloodied body on top of his, violating him. Fane and Vexal’s energy signatures, overclocked and irreparably dangerous.

They were beautiful.

He felt tears run down his leathered cheeks at the thought. He hated how beautiful Fane’s work was. Brutal, grotesque, but layered with an elegance that made Varian feel like an amateur.

He rubbed his face and pulled up his display, going immediately to Myth’s feed. Or better yet, 001X’s feed. She was so visible now to the public, critical to their success. If the AAN wanted to control the future, they needed her loyalty, and if there was going to even be a future,

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then Fane couldn't just be allowed to run rampant to destroy all of Titan. Rule it, yes; destroy it from the ground up, no.

Additionally, he knew it was only a matter of time before she started remembering things, especially after coming in direct contact with a Catalyst Well. She would at least remember him or Voxx.

He grinned wickedly from ear to ear, easing back in his seat, a quiet laugh escaping his throat. Of course, Thallion Voxx.

Perfectly placed, and with the subject's, no doubt altered, memories, he would be able to push her right into the AAN's arms. With Valkyrie there to comfort her in a time of need, and her conclusion of her past, she would agree to let the AAN do everything they could to get her answers.

He pulled his console forward, fingers flicking rapidly through encrypted directories. Layers upon layers of sealed files rolled past his view. Decades of unauthorised data he had collected. His personal archive of brilliance.

Finally, he found what he was looking for. He had personally collected it decades of cycle-years ago during another terrible time when things had become too... difficult. Two things. The first one, a detailed log of the corrupted experimental trials with just enough intact data to paint a very specific picture. It told of two subjects, perfectly compatible with Quasar-tier energies, that were subjected to repetitive, extreme trauma exposure. After each event, they went through extensive memory corrective simulation trials. It was beautiful and detailed, one of his more prized sets of experiments, if he did say so himself.

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And the second was only a file name and the access codes needed to read it without redaction. Time-stamped and untraceable, it was the day that Subject 001X was officially declared terminated.

Varian dropped the data as a packet deep into one of Voxx's personal caches, one he knew the Commander obsessively monitored for leaks of unauthorised traffic. He would find it sooner rather than later.

And once he did, the Commander would inevitably leak it to Myth, either seeking to see if she remembered or if she had returned from the dead. He would have to kill her again!

A soft, giddy laugh bubbled from Varian's throat; he knew the next step was clear. Fane's monsters. Where to drop them? He hummed to himself as he pulled up the topographical map of Titan and tapped into the subterranean overlays. The central city was too predictable and had robust automatic protection, so that wouldn't do. The Verge was unstable, but held too many allies. No, he needed... *Skelter Reach*.

Deep enough in Dreg territory that the damage wouldn't leak to any of the main cities, and close enough to a Catalyst Well to stir panic. Not close enough for it to be in any real danger, just enough to thin out the herd a bit.

He pinned three specific coordinates, all circling an old subterranean hub where several abandoned supply routes converged. Perfect for the narrative that these monsters were Dregs going out of control, though he didn't know how well that story would hold once the news caught whiff of these new monsters; they probably would sniff out the difference eventually. Something about Fane's new creations caused a worry in the back of his mind, something that wasn't quite right, but he shrugged it away. That would be for Fane to deal with, considering he started this war.

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He uploaded the coordinates to Fane's private server, included a rough threat-potential remark, and washed his hands of it. He stood and limped across his office to his lab, past stasis rows and suspended vials, all the way until reaching a surgical cradle. He ran his hand tenderly along the sterile edge, mentally taking stock of its condition. It was a viable method for extracting high-energy genetic material. Blood and matter primarily, and not just a drop; he needed to gather enough litres, preferably with the subject in immediate distress. And he needed updated matter from both of his primary subjects. All he needed to do was to get it activated before Fane set his monsters loose. He worked quickly; the clock was ticking, and even though Fane wasn't there, he felt him over his shoulder, surveying his work, there to punish and correct as needed. And Varian relished the feeling.

Chapter 27

Myth sat up with a sharp breath, her whole body tense and sore. The ceiling above her was dim and slightly familiar, but it wasn't the containment room. The warmth next to her grounded her, and she didn't need to turn to know where she was. Darius, his presence like a low ember lying beside her and soothing her nerves. She let her hand drift over the sheets, and his eyes flew open the second she moved, his arm already coming around her waist, pulling her to him tightly. "How do you feel?" he asked, his voice raw with worry.

She gave him a small smile. "I feel... great?" She blinked again, her words sounding strange in her ears. "I mean, I don't remember too much, honestly. But thank you for, well, everything."

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“Of course,” he murmured, his grip on her tightening just slightly. “But you’re only here on supervision. I told them I’d keep my eyes on you at all times. Figured you wouldn’t appreciate indefinite containment.”

She exhaled hard, relief rushing through her chest. “**Thank you,**” she whispered, gently pressing a kiss to his cheek.

He gave her a crooked grin, tiredness still clinging to his face. “Well, I can’t exactly do much without my partner.”

She giggled a bit, warmth spreading through her chest. She shifted, rolling on top of him and resting her head against his collarbone. She felt his body relax under hers and she took a deep breath, breathing in his smoky scent.

“So then what?” she asked.

He rubbed his hand over her back lazily. “We’ve got increased patrols after the monster incident. But you’re on light duty unless something crazy hits.”

She raised an eyebrow. “So what do I do then?”

“You’re doing public image work. Direct orders from the High Chancellor herself.” He smirked proudly. “Smile, sign autographs, assure the masses that we have everything under control.”

She groaned dramatically. “Please, no...”

He laughed. “Don’t worry, I’ll do all the talking. Just don’t punch anyone important.”

“No promises,” she snorted.

He smiled gently at her, his eyes locking with hers. “Myth. We need to talk.”

Her smile faded as he shifted beneath her, gently brushing a stray lock of hair behind her ear.

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“First, really. How do you feel?” he asked quietly.

She opened her mouth to reassure him, but she snapped it shut without a word, letting her body fall back onto his chest gently. She could hear his heartbeat, slow and strong, as her fingers traced the scars along his ribs. “Physically, I think I’m okay,” she said quietly. “Mentally and emotionally, not so much.”

His hand moved in soothing circles along her back, letting her take her time.

“My energy is still pretty low,” she admitted, chewing her lip. “And yesterday, I don’t know. I felt awful after I left. I went to see a friend, but it... it didn’t go great. And then my comtech went out, and by the time I got back...”

“You really scared me,” he said softly.

“I’m sorry.” She was slightly shocked by his vulnerability.

“I forgive you,” he said with a lopsided smile, pulling her tighter. He was quiet for a moment before clearing his throat. “While you were out of commission, they took a few blood samples from me. Tests and the usual.”

She tensed involuntarily.

“Next, they want to poke around in you for a bit,” he continued softly, as if sensing her apprehension. “But after that, if you get the okay, you will be cleared for duty.”

Her heart leapt slightly at the prospect of being out in the field again so quickly. But something still bothered her. “How many times did you have to...?” she asked hesitantly.

He blinked, confused for a second, before a look of clarity crossed his face. “Synergise with you?”

She nodded, her cheeks heating up.

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“A few,” he said, his voice laced with tiredness. “I had to come in a few times between shifts. It was... a long day for me.”

She bit her lip as something twisted inside her chest. She saw the exhaustion creeping in at the corners of his eyes, his normal staunch bravado gone.

He did so much for me, she thought, he has always been there for me. And he has no one.

Her arms moved on their own as she wrapped them tighter around his neck, pressing her cheek to the warm line of his throat. He smelled like smoke and metal, and she felt a tear slip down her cheek before she could stop it.

“I’m so sorry, Darius,” she whispered.

“Hey now,” he murmured. “Look at me, will ya?”

He tilted her chin gently, thumb brushing under her eye, the heat of his hands quickly drying her face.

“I’ll be alright,” he said, a crooked smile on his lips. “I promise.”

She felt a strong ache in her heart; he had been there for her, kept her secrets, stood up for her repeatedly, she thought. She felt a strange warmth grow inside her, her energy rising beneath her skin, moving through her like a quiet, rushing current. She leaned in, gently landing a soft kiss on his lips. “Thank you,” she breathed, her voice trembling slightly.

Darius looked stunned, his molten eyes glowing a deep golden-orange underneath his dark lashes. “I promise I will always do everything in my power to keep you safe,” he murmured, his voice a soothing rumble, but his eyes bored into hers, a fierce intensity shining through the fatigue.

Despite his clear exhaustion, his body radiated an undeniable magnetism, pulling and teasing her energy. She let her fingers tangle in his hair, tugging lightly as she kissed him again, a

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fervour rising through her that set her nerves ablaze. A low groan escaped his lips as he pulled her closer, her chest arching into the hard planes of his body.

“Darius...” she gasped, her breath coming in shallow gasps as her body ached, her energy buzzing under her skin like a tidal wave.

He gripped her hips tightly, pulling her closer as he rolled them over, pinning her beneath his massive body. She felt her cheeks flush as she realised their mutual state of undress, her hair a dishevelled mess splayed across his pillows. His eyes burned into hers as he settled his weight between her thighs, the heat of his body searing her skin.

An intoxicating rush of adrenaline clouded her vision as he crushed his lips to hers in a fierce kiss. She felt herself meeting his passion without hesitation, gasping as his hand drifted up her thigh, his body pushing her legs further apart. He paused, watching her face intently, giving her a moment to settle before claiming her lips in another searing kiss, stealing her breath away.

His hips rolled against her, letting her feel the thick, hot ridge of his arousal, her own body reacting with a burning need for him. In that moment, she lost herself in the storm of her own need, feeling the slide of their sweat-slicked bodies as he moved gently, his body rocking hers with powerful thrusts. She felt her nails digging into his back, his muscles rolling and tensing under her hands, until at last she felt herself shatter against him in a burst of energy and ecstasy. She cried out his name in a hoarse voice, the sheer intensity of his heat threatening to consume her. With a guttural groan, Darius’s body shuddered above her, his body moving gently against hers until the energy between them died down.

Pulling her tight into his arms, Darius cradled her trembling body tight to his slick chest. He pressed tender kisses to her temple, her vision slowly clearing as he kissed the tip of her nose.

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“Are you okay?” he asked, his deep voice slightly hoarse.

She smiled up at him, her brain foggy and struggling to make a coherent sentence.

“Mmmm. I am,” she giggled slightly. “Are you okay?”

“I’m amazing,” he said, her body vibrating with his laughter. Rolling off the bed, he scooped her up with one muscular arm, carrying her towards the bathroom. “Matter of fact,” he said, brushing her hair out of her face, “I’ve never felt better.”

He set her down gently in the massive shower, the bathroom illuminated only by the golden streak of light near the floor. He reached up, adjusting the temperature before turning the shower on, warm water instantly washing over her skin like a soft rainfall. She admired how his body moved in the dim light, his skin still faintly glowing from her energy. He turned to catch her watching him, a slow smile creeping across his face. He captured her mouth in a searing kiss, his hands roaming over her body greedily as the warm water washed over their hot bodies. Steam rolled off his body as he pressed against her, trapping her body between his and the coolness of the shower wall.

Darius growled against her lips, the sound sending a shock to her core as his leg slipped between hers, parting her thighs invitingly as he rocked against her. She felt a rush of breath escape her lips as her body sparked with pleasure, her energy rushing to his. She pushed her hips forward, meeting his, feeling the sweet fullness and stretch of his body in hers.

Darius snarled low as he began to move with her, his mouth swallowing her groans of pleasure. She felt his energy rush through her with each powerful thrust, driving her more and more delirious, a roaring fire pulsing through her core. She clung to him, her fingers digging into his shoulders as she felt waves of energy and pleasure wash over her. She felt his rhythm falter

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before he surged forward in a final roar of pleasure, his energy enveloping the shower in an inferno.

They stayed locked together, their hearts pounding in tandem as the steaming water washed over their still-shaking forms. She looked up to find him watching her, his eyes warm and soft as he kissed her softly. After a moment, he pulled away, reaching for a nearby cloth. Without saying anything, he began to wash her slowly, his careful movements leaving trails of fire across her skin.

She closed her eyes, letting him move her softly, her body relaxing under his rough hands as he gently worked over her muscles. Her mind was hazy, and as she felt his fingers gently move through her hair, she felt tears threaten again as her body relaxed against him, simultaneously mellowed and energised.

After he was done, she rinsed as he quickly washed himself down. She let the water rinse through her hair, the long tangles finally falling free down her back. After he finished, he helped her out of the shower, the heat from the floor quickly drying them as she noticed their uniforms were already laid out for them, cleaned and perfectly repaired. She didn't ask how, knowing that being a Captain certainly had its perks.

Beside her, she heard Darius's stomach growl furiously. She startled, surprised as a laugh slipped from her lips. "Are you hungry too?" she asked lightly.

He looked sheepishly at her as he zipped up the last few sections of his uniform and reached for his outer coat. "Yes, actually. Famished."

"Who knew saving the world worked up such an appetite?" she laughed, tugging her jacket on.

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He grinned, motioning for her to follow, but instead of heading towards the main mess hall like she expected, he led her to his private transport dock. She hesitated behind him, the soft white and blue hues of the horizon sparkling against the white egg-shaped shell. “Aren’t I supposed to... you know...”

He looked over his shoulder at her, eyes full of mischief. “I am supposed to be keeping an eye on you. Which I am. Both eyes. I didn’t say that it had to be here.”

His hand lifted, gently pulling her forward for a soft kiss, and she felt her apprehension melt away. She followed him giddily into the transport, its interior shifting from soft white to a light blue as they took off through Helion’s mid-tier air lanes. She sat beside him as they fell gently into traffic, her hand finding his as the motion caused her stomach to lurch slightly. Through the curved windows, she watched Helion unfold around them in wide arcs of gleaming towers, glittering sky bridges, and transient gardens reaching for the sky between massive solar arcs. He squeezed her hand softly and she leaned against him as she watched the traffic merge around them, guiding them through the shimmering maglev lane and over the bustling streets below.

“So I figured,” he said as they glided past a glowing helix of golden-trimmed buildings, “since we have an easy day, we could have something other than cafeteria mush.”

She blinked at him, shocked. “Are you sure being out like this is going to be okay?” A flicker of worry flashed through her mind; she didn’t want to get him in trouble, again.

He smiled at her easily. “Absolutely.” He gave her a gentle kiss on her forehead. “Besides, this counts as official public time. I can make it sound very official if anyone important asks.”

She snorted, her worry melting away. “Ah yes, right. Official,” she giggled.

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“Exactly,” he said, his voice mock-serious. “Gotta choose strategic meeting places, low stress and good visibility.”

She laughed heartily at the thought, and the sound of people rose around them as the transport docked in one of the mid-tier Helion districts. The crowds swarmed around them busily, Luminals and Apexes with a few Echelon sanitary workers moving about busily. A few heads turned and whispers echoed here and there, but for the most part, people seemed not to notice their arrival. Young professionals hurried past in immaculately tailored uniforms, while the vendors that lined the walkways hawked everything from colour-shifting sweets to health supplements. Kids in hover-boots zipped past street performers, their glowing instruments pulsing with live sound that wove in colours through the air.

Darius didn't let go of her hand as he led her confidently down the walkway, weaving through the brightly dressed street traffic until they stopped in front of a sleek techno-hut. She looked up and down the glowing storefronts, the scent of roasted meats and spicy cheeses hitting her immediately, her stomach grumbling audibly in response.

He laughed, looking back at her. “Welcome to the Warped Ladle.” He said as they descended a brightly coloured spiral path made of living vines that opened into a cosy techno-hut. Its green-glass-styled walls nested into the living wood of the Verdant Spire, its name pulsing faintly overhead in neon-green lights and synthetic sprouts.

As soon as he led her through the doors, she was hit with multiple delicious smells at once. Sweet, savoury, and spicy, all dancing through the air, earning another rumbling growl and cramp from her stomach. The inside lighting was warm and low, with floating orbs casting a soft orange-pink glow over the mismatched tables, a sharp contrast from the bright white light filtering through the canopy of the Spire. The chairs and benches were woven from light-reactive

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threads that shimmered in time with the soft ambient music filtering through the leafy glass wall. A marble-wood counter was spread with various foods that sizzled on a lev-plate, and Myth could see a small open kitchen through the back, where a leafy-green chef worked fast and loud.

Darius led her to a corner booth surrounded by a hazy window, and she sank onto the soft, moss-foam seat, settling in beside his warm body.

“This place is... cosy!” she said, trying to contain her awe.

“It’s my favourite place to grab a snack when I need a break from Helion politics,” he said easily, handing her a menu.

She scanned the bright menu, the different dish names jumping out at her. Tempest Tofu, Seared Plantain Ribbons, Shock-Sauced Turkey. She had no idea what to get, and the pictures only solidified that it all looked delicious. “Anything you’d recommend?” she asked, looking over at Darius’s menu.

“Safe bet?” he said, leaning over her shoulder and tapping through the menu pages. “The Thornapple Stir-Fry or the Magma-Baked Spuds are delicious. But if you’re feeling bold...”

She shot him a look. “You’re about to suggest something ridiculous, aren’t you?”

“I personally love the Inferno Bowl,” he finished smugly.

“Uh. Yeah. Darius, what is an Inferno Bowl?” Her eyes narrowed at him.

“Super-heated Ashvine and Lure-Fruit-wrapped Silverlash Eels. It’s so hot it glows when it arrives. One time it even melted through a table.” His stomach chimed in at the end of his sentence, as if reassuring her it was as good as he thought it was.

“And this doesn’t hurt your insides or anything?” she asked.

“Nope.”

“That explains a lot.” She snorted.

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A waiter approached their booth before he could answer. A tall, warm amber-skinned man with a silver braid coiled over his shoulder. His apron flickered with shifting text as he pulled out a tablet to take their orders.

“Captain Valkyrie,” he said with a smooth voice and sparkling white smile. “Lovely to see you again.”

“Thank you for having me,” he replied smoothly. “I’ll have one Inferno Bowl, and...?”

“Oh, ummm.” She looked at her menu briefly. “I’ll have the Thornapple Stir-Fry. Thank you.”

The waiter bowed and sauntered off, leaving Myth to study her partner more. “So how often do you come here, Captain Valkyrie?” she asked with a smile tugging at her lips.

He rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly. “More often than I should,” he replied. “Mid-level cafés like this keep track of who's trending, so we get extra perks here and there.”

She leaned against his warm body briefly. “We should come here again sometime!”

“We could certainly do that,” he smiled down at her. She smiled wider and looked out the window again. The hum of the café surrounded them as the waiter returned shortly with their food, a jaunty smile on his face as he winked at Darius before disappearing into the back of the café.

The food itself was better than she’d been expecting. The Thornapple had a sweet and spicy burn that lingered on her tongue slightly, causing her to down her accompanying drink in a hurry. Darius had to stop twice to blow his nose heartily while eating the Inferno Bowl, the bubbling bowl of assorted peppers and coals making both of their eyes water.

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“You know... you could... maybe order a medium Inferno Bowl next time,” she teased, mock-inching away from him.

“Then the food wins,” he lamented between bites. “I can’t let the bowl sense weakness.”

She laughed, finishing her stir-fry quickly, her body relishing the taste and feeling of food. Even if it did little for her energy-wise, it still felt so good to be full both ways. As they finished and headed back to his transport, she felt more at ease in public than she probably ever had. Not ducking through alleyways, but striding down the main streets like she belonged.

As they boarded his transport again, he pulled her down close next to him, a heavy arm draped over her shoulders while the other he flung over his slightly extended belly.

“Ugh,” he groaned. “I think I ate too much.”

She laughed, shaking her head. “Don’t let the food win!”

He laughed heartily and quickly tapped in their next location. “We are heading to see Dr. Vaelith,” he said as he settled back, the transport easing them into the steady traffic before rocketing through the sky towards Blackroot Verge.

“It’s her private medical facility. I thought you could use some privacy,” he said, his fingers teasing the ends of her hair. She leaned against him, watching the city far beneath their feet, admiring the criss-crossed bridges of light that looked like spider silk below them.

“Thank you.” She nestled into his side deeper, letting herself get lost in the dizzying view from his arms. The parks and public gardens glittered like precious jewels in suspended glass mega-pods between the towering spires of crystal and gold, all blurring past like a perfect mural.

It felt like only a few minutes passed before the transport slowed to a crawl, dropping altitude over a mass of moving green rock, the tangled mass of vines revealing a transport dock

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as they connected with a soft click into the private transport bay. The space was protected with thick vines and transparent glass shielding, casting a soft green and gold light along the floor.

Dr. Vaelith was already waiting for them, and she looked exactly like Myth had remembered. Strikingly beautiful, her calm, earthy-green skin was rich with glints of gold and emerald; her bright green eyes sparkled with energy as she rushed forward.

“Nyx!” She beamed down at her, catching her in a quick but fierce hug. “Stars, have I been waiting to meet you, officially.”

Myth smiled brightly at her, slightly taken off-guard. The doctor's eyes sparkled with bright green energy that sparked back and forth from her eyes to her hair, which was coiled in long, dark, intricate braids around her head. “Yeah, it seems like every time I see you, something is going wrong,” she said sheepishly.

“It does seem that way,” Rhea laughed, pulling her gently down the hall. “But don’t worry, nothing is wrong. We are just getting the basics today!”

The interior of Rhea’s clinic was nothing short of serene. Softly lit with golden sunlight that filtered through the crystal ceiling panels, causing rainbow fractals to dance across Myth’s skin.

Vines grew along every available surface in spiralling patterns, wrapping around consoles and tech alike, merging together with tiny bioluminescent buds that blinked in a rhythm of their own. Somewhere in the rafters, a gentle breeze wafted through, tinkling the crystal wind chimes in a soft whisper.

“Don’t worry, it’s just me here today!” Rhea called cheerily.

“Well, that’s a nice break for you,” Darius said, his deep voice rumbling behind her.

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“I’ll say! Look! Verdant Green resonance,” Rhea said, pointing to the light blooming underfoot, the moss and marble floor reacting in time to her footsteps. “They only activate like this if they like the company.”

“Well, look at that, Nyx. The floor likes you,” Darius laughed. Myth snorted at him, noting the distinct lack of light beneath his boots smugly.

Rhea sat her down on a soft medical bed. “This will be painless,” she said with a soft prick where a large medical cuff drew blood from Myth’s arm. She felt a faint, tingling hum through her body as Rhea smiled, mapping the energy output on her console.

“It seems like you have recovered nicely!” Rhea chimed. “I will admit I was a little worried about sending you home, but it seems like the Captain has taken great care of you!”

Myth felt her cheeks heat up slightly, and Darius cleared his throat. He was standing in front of a massive vine bookcase, books and scrolls overflowing from each shelf. “Of course! I told you she would be fine. And I am always right,” he said with a smirk.

Myth laughed at that, but didn’t argue; she didn’t even want to think what would have happened to her if she hadn’t had Darius or Vexal.

“Annnnd... done!” Rhea sang, clicking the cuff free.

Myth stood and stretched her arm, her bicep slightly sore from the cuff.

“Right this way!” Rhea turned in a flurry of white robes and led them into her inner office. It was a beautiful, sunlit cove with a tree growing high in one corner, its roots vanishing into a blue-green pond that danced with small, brightly coloured fish. The tree branches swayed gently against the vaulted white marble ceiling, with the lower branches heavy with soft, lavender-coloured fruit, faintly humming with bees.

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Darius led her to a low, curved couch woven of soft plant fibres that moulded perfectly to their bodies as they sank into it. She instinctively let her legs curl up beneath her comfortably, Darius's arm finding its way around her shoulders again.

“So,” Rhea began, leaning back in a low wooden chair, mimicking Myth's position. “The good news is you're still a freak of nature. And a healthy one, too!”

“Rhea!” Darius laughed, and Myth couldn't help but giggle a bit. Rhea pulled up a large screen displaying a host of different health information about Myth.

“But. Your mutation energy is extremely volatile,” Rhea continued. “You're scoring some of the highest energy markers ever. On top of that, your body works in tandem to somewhat self-regulate your output. Meaning, even though you have high energy, you should have perfect control under normal, no-stress circumstances. Which is astronomical for your mutation type.”

“Just what is her mutation type?” Darius interjected.

“She is an Anomaly Hybrid. And a tri-fused anomaly at that: Temporal, spatial, and entropic conversion.” Rhea swiped through her screen, pointing to a set of numbers. “Here is her mutation index and energy output. Her mutation Tier is Quasar. She is, right now, the only natural-born Quasar mutation in Titan's index. Voxx, King, and Darius can all reach near-Quasar or Quasar states under extreme duress. King and Darius specifically reaching this in direct correlation to you, Nyx. So I am assigning my recommendation for Myth to be fully registered Quasar. It will be a celebration!”

“That is amazing!” Darius said enthusiastically, turning to Myth.

She felt her mouth part slightly, the news settling around her uncertainly. “That's... incredible,” she said finally. “But what exactly does that mean for me?”

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Rhea tilted her head thoughtfully, her long, dark braids slipping over her shoulder. “Well, it means you are now Titan’s most eligible bachelorette, for one,” she said with a slow smile.

Myth blinked, the response slightly throwing her off.

“It’s like this,” Rhea continued. “You’re a naturally born Quasar from what I can tell. It’s been at least fifty cycle-years since that’s happened. Everybody is going to want to see the best that Titan has to offer!”

Darius murmured in agreement with her. “It’s a wonderful thing for science, too.”

“Yes!” Rhea said brightly. “It means we get a real-life example of how someone with your mutation type functions! If that’s okay with you, of course.”

Myth chewed her lip, eyes flicking to the soft moss under her feet. Part of her flushed warmly from the praise, but the lingering secrets of her life threatened to dampen the happy moment. “I just...” She paused briefly, swallowing the weird knot forming in her throat. “I’ve never really been in the public eye like that. I don’t know what to do or say...”

Darius must’ve felt the change in her body, because his hand gently cupped her jaw, lifting her face toward him. “What’s wrong?” he asked, his voice soft.

She hesitated before whispering, “I just... I just don’t know how to feel about all this.”

He nodded, his eyes gentle. “I get that.” His thumb brushed her cheek. “When Rhea came out as a healer, all of Verdant Green celebrated for a whole cycle-year. They even made a statue.”

Myth glanced at Rhea, who was chuckling softly. “Thankfully, I was able to donate it for materials a few cycles after. So you see, things will quiet down eventually.”

She nodded, settling back against Darius, who kissed her temple gently.

“Point is,” he said, “you won’t go through any of this alone. We’re here for you. All of us.”

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Rhea nodded in agreement. “I will always try to do what’s best for you. Speaking of, officially you were here last night. You haven’t been actually released yet, but I let him take you home because it really seemed like you needed it. So if anyone asks, you were here.”

Myth felt a flood of thankfulness. “Thank you,” she said, relief settling in her bones.

“Of course,” Rhea said with an easy smile. “We’re not the AAN. We are your friends, and hopefully your family, if you’ll let us be.”

Darius and Rhea smiled at her, and she felt something warm clench at her chest.

Rhea cleared her throat sheepishly. “That said, I may have taken the liberty of running a few extra tests.”

Myth tilted her head and waited.

“So I’ll skip to the chase. Normally, after a certain mutation index, the subject can no longer naturally conceive offspring. The energy and mutation load is just too unstable during gestation. But because of your healing factor, you can!”

Myth froze. “Wait. You mean...”

“You can have kids, Nyx! Naturally. If and when you choose to do so. You are already on the standardised contraceptive loop, but we can take you off that anytime if you ever decide to start a family!”

Myth’s heart skipped in her chest, and she was afraid Darius could hear it. She had spent all of her time planning and infiltrating; she hadn’t thought about kids or the future after. She hadn’t even considered it an option. For a wild second, she imagined Darius holding a flaming-haired baby and a few more skittering around his legs. She blinked hard, washing away the images, heat flooding her face and causing her hands to prickle.

“I had honestly never considered that an option,” she murmured.

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Rhea smiled kindly. “Most don’t. Normally, the family life is left to those with less mutative energies, but this is an exceptional case. And I wanted you to hear it from me first, without the Council breathing down your neck.”

Darius gave her hand a gentle squeeze. “Thank you, Rhea. And what about for now? Is she released?”

Rhea laughed, signing some digital documents with a flourish. “Released to you. The AAN certainly wouldn’t just let her out with anybody, but yes, she’s released! And outside of the regular check-ins, she is free to live her life.”

Myth exhaled slowly, the words wrapping around her like a blanket.

“And just so you’re informed,” Rhea continued, pulling up another data sheet, “with your new designation, you’ll get a crest and Council passcode later this week. It’ll be under Darius for obvious reasons. And,” she turned to Darius, “I’ve attached a copy of her synergy data to your file. You can review it whenever you have the time.”

He nodded. “Of course.”

Rhea closed the final set of glowing screens with a soft smile. “Last thing I’ll say is just be prepared. News travels fast on Titan, and I just submitted your dossier recommendations. If it’s accepted, the whole grid will know within hours.”

Darius exhaled deeply and pushed up from the couch, gently pulling Myth along with him. “Yeah, I figured as much,” he said. “We’ve got to make a public appearance anyway. We’ll notify T.E.B. where we’re headed.”

Rhea nodded and led them back to the transport, her robes and hair catching the dappled light as she moved. “Take my schedule,” she said over her shoulder, waving her comtech at

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Darius. His comtech sent out a pleasant ping in response. “I’ll be by when my schedule opens up again,” Rhea said with a smile.

As they reached the transport, Rhea turned and wrapped Myth in a tight hug. “If you ever feel overwhelmed,” she said softly, “remember that your partner is literally there to save you. You aren’t doing this alone.”

Myth nodded, unsure why her throat felt so tight. Rhea pulled back and looked at Darius, then back to her. “Take care of each other,” she said, finally releasing Myth.

“We will. Thank you again,” Darius said, placing a quick hand on Rhea’s shoulder before boarding his transport, Myth following after giving Rhea a small wave.

As the transport lifted smoothly into the air and banked into traffic, Myth’s thoughts spun, her whole body still relaxed from Rhea’s office. She barely registered the change of terrain from the dense jungles of Blackroot Verge to the Crown Canopy of Helion Prime. The sweeping infrastructure raced to the sky in a web of glittering glass domes, greenways, and vertical gardens cascading between districts like jewelled veins.

She felt Darius pull her over gently onto his lap, his arms wrapped solidly around her middle, trapping her in place.

“Myth,” he asked quietly, “are you alright?”

She leaned into him, exhaling hard. “Yeah. It’s just... a lot to take in. I’ve never even thought about having a family quite like that before.” Her voice cracked slightly at the end.

He waited, gently rubbing the small of her back with a warm hand.

“I want one,” she finally admitted. “A family. I want kids. I don’t just want to be a tool or a weapon. I want more than fighting until I die or something kills me.” She rested her head against his shoulder, her heart thudding unnaturally in her chest.

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“I want a family too,” Darius said finally, his voice a quiet rumble. “For most Apexes, that kind of life’s off the table. Finding mutations compatible for long-term civilian life is rare, to say the least. Let alone for the people attached to those mutations to actually be compatible. Most of us don’t even try.”

Myth turned her head to the soft hum of the newsfeed flickering on, a report rolling about another monster attack. This time it was near the outer reactors, and Eira and King were on the scene, moving in perfect sync, their combined power slicing through the chaos with crisp efficiency. Myth studied their forms, their flawless choreography of energy and body, and wondered what connection they had to make that level of synergy possible.

“You know, most Apexes would find the whole family thing boring,” he said, studying her intently.

“I’d kill for boring,” she muttered, turning back to the screen, watching the well-polished anchor give their praises to the Apex duo.

Darius was quiet behind her for a long moment, watching the newsfeed with her in a comfortable silence.

“Well,” he started, his voice tentative, “I could put in a request for the contraceptive block for us? If that’s something you want?”

Her breath caught. “You mean with me?”

“If you want me?” He was almost bashful, and the idea made her dizzy.

She launched herself forward, wrapping her arms around his neck tightly as a surprised laugh poured from his throat.

“That would make me so happy, Darius!” she gasped, excitement buzzing through her body.

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He held her tightly, a wide smile on his face; his voice was steady, but she could hear the relief in it. “I’ll have to put in a formal request for permanent Resonance Bonding,” he said.

“That’s for life, you know? Or at least until one of us dies.”

She looked into his amber eyes, his words making something twist and bloom in her chest. This was by far the most open she had ever seen him.

“Myth,” he asked gently, “do you want to be mine and Bond to me for life?”

Her answer was a breathless squeal as she kissed him hard and fast, joy spilling out of her in waves. “Yes! A million times, yes!”

Darius grinned wildly, kissing her again passionately before he gently pulled away, breathless, as the transport console chimed incessantly.

“We’re almost at Veyrix Spire for the press interview that the High Chancellor arranged,” he clarified.

She nodded, trying to steady herself after the rush of emotions coursing through her veins.

Darius gently stood as the windows of the transport opened to the large upper plaza district, the soaring news building’s transport hub buzzing with activity. He brushed and straightened his uniform, mumbling under his breath, “They are going to nitpick everything.” He turned to her. “Just don’t let them get to you, okay?”

She nodded, already straightening her own uniform, running her hands quickly through her curls and checking her reflection in her comtech. Her cheeks were still flushed slightly, but other than that, everything else seemed to be in order. “How do I look?” she asked, giving a small twirl.

“Beautiful,” he said without hesitation.

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She blushed deeper. “Well, thank you, sir,” she teased with a giggle.

He laughed heartily as his comtech buzzed twice, signalling they were docked. He offered his arm, and together they stepped out and directly into the buzz of the upper district’s news terminal at the Veyrix Spire. Dozens of reporters moved through the marble-floored lobby, holographic feeds twisting around glass columns and energy screens blinking updates in every colour, flooding her vision. Cameras flashed like lightning, burning her retinas, and she noticed the T.E.B. handlers moving fast, struggling to assist the dozens of assistants who rushed forward, slapping headsets into producers' and news anchors' hands.

Nyx blinked hard, glad that Darius had her arm as they were ushered through the halls to a main stage area. Everything around her shimmered in a haze of glass, and screens displayed their names in stylised flairs above the main screen. They were seated and miked up before Nyx could even get her bearings, the speed with which the assistants had them sitting almost dizzying.

The woman who sat opposite them looked like she had been poured out of liquid obsidian and dipped in gold. Her name shone in bold text on her shoulder: **ABAZARA VELVET**. And in smaller text underneath: *CHIEF ANCHOR, PRIORITY BROADCAST TIER*. She wore a sculpted plum suit with sharp shoulders and glimmering brass medals and news rankings. Her hair was woven into gleaming coils that floated ever so slightly around her head. Her eyes were the most unnerving thing about her. Solid white with expensive lens implants, no pupils, just shifting halos of data readouts.

An assistant scrambled to the dark corners as the studio’s lights were focused on the main stage, a countdown going off before a voice from the shadows called, “We are live in three... two...”

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“We are here today with the Captain of the AAN Apex Corps, Captain Darius Valkyrie, and the newly announced Quasar-class Operative, Nyx,” Abazara purred, her voice smooth as she extended a black-and-gold-splotched hand towards Darius. He took it diplomatically, giving a firm nod.

“And Nyx!” Abazara turned to her, her synthetic eyes scanning Nyx closely. “Being the first confirmed Quasar on Titan in nearly fifty years must feel surreal for you. Not only that, but being immediately paired with the Captain, it's clear the AAN has our strongest and best on the front lines.”

Nyx sat tensely beside Darius, trying not to squint in the glare of the studio dome, and she felt like every movement was magnified. She could hear her pulse in her ears and took a deep breath, feeling Darius's hand on her knee, gently steadying her, and she focused back on what Abazara was saying.

“Fane Dryst, a long-thought-dead criminal, has returned and declared war on the AAN and Titan. His force of monsters terrorises the public daily in an effort to weaken Apex lines. Captain Valkyrie, are we safe from these monsters? What can we do to prepare for a monster attack?”

Darius leaned forward, looking sternly into the cameras. “Stay vigilant, report anything you see that is out of the ordinary, so we can assess the situation before things get out of hand. And above all, if you see a monster, run. Do not try to fight it. This is exactly why the Apex Corps exists: to protect the people of Titan.”

Abazara nodded affirmatively. “And you heard it straight from the AAN: do not try to fight these *monsters*! That is the burden of our elite protectors—those born to hold the line.”

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She turned slightly, her lenses flickering through a spectrum of data. “Now, there are many of the citizens of Titan who worry, what is the AAN doing in all of this? Is our safety left solely up to the Apex Corps?”

“The Aegis Ascension Nexus is the authority that exists to ensure that chaos like this never takes root in our cities,” Darius said assuredly. “They choose and train every operative, every enforcer, and every diplomat so when an emergency strikes, the Apex Corps is prepared to protect and fight. For you, for Titan, and for our future.”

Abazara looked impressed and nodded strongly before pivoting smoothly to Nyx, her voice tilting with curiosity. “And Nyx, what a time to become an Apex during these unprecedented times. How does it feel to be partnered with such a prestigious figure, who is such a strong symbol of the AAN and the Apex Corps?”

Nyx’s mouth ran dry, and she forced a smile. “It’s an amazing opportunity. Not only to learn and use my talent for good, but to also serve Titan to the best of my abilities.”

She felt Darius squeeze her knee and she breathed a sigh of relief, thankful for having seen enough news bulletins to come up with a diplomatic response. She admired Darius all the more for how easily he seemed to handle the questioning.

Abazara was rambling on while Nyx only half-listened, letting Darius wrap the interview with ease as the timer chimed and the ON AIR sign blinked off. As soon as the lights dimmed, she let out her breath and turned to stand as the assistants removed her mic. She watched as Darius said a few quiet words to Abazara before he turned and stood, the main doors opening and light flooding into the studio. He ushered Nyx in front of him, and they followed security out down a side exit, the roar of the press echoing from the main halls. As they entered Darius’s transport, she felt herself slightly relax, finally safe from hundreds of eyes that followed them

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everywhere. They had barely sat down when Darius's comtech chirped alive. He tapped his wrist, and a cascade of glowing interfaces shimmered around his forearm. Without missing a beat, he started speaking in clipped tones, sending directives and, from what she could tell, scheduling missions. The entire cabin responded to his voice, the walls shifting to display tactical overlays as he issued a live debrief to the AAN core systems.

Myth turned, leaning her head against the glass as she watched Titan roll by beneath them. The sky was fractured into soft pinks and violets as twilight began to fall on the horizon, and she realised they had been out all day. Time had skipped past her; it felt like it was only a few hours ago they were having breakfast, but the emptiness in her stomach let her know that it had, in fact, been a full day.

When they landed, Darius leaned over, swiping away the many screens. "I've got an in-person report. You can come if you want, or you can wait for me in my room."

She didn't hesitate. "Room." She had had enough of AAN bureaucracy for today.

He gave her a smile and leaned in, giving her a quick kiss on the head before he turned and left without another word. She watched him disappear before she walked into his suite, dropping onto his bed and letting her body fall back into the cool firmness.

Her mind raced with the events of the day as she released a long breath. This was the first time in the day that she had quiet-time to herself. She thought about visiting Vexal, but decided against it quickly. That was a bad idea right now, not until she was sure that she had time. She didn't know when Darius was going to be back and knew she couldn't afford for him to come back to her gone. She felt a tinge of guilt in her gut and she rolled over, agitated. She had come here for revenge, and now she was planning a family with one of the people she was supposed to be destroying. And the thing was, she didn't want to destroy the Apex Corps anymore. Change it,

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yes, without a doubt. But there was no coming clean now. Darius would never forgive her if he learned the truth, and Vexal would probably kill her if she betrayed him.

She absent-mindedly flipped on his media console and started flipping through the channels, trying to ignore the flood of worry threatening to break her mind. She wanted a family; she hadn't lied about that. She didn't know exactly when she had started wanting that, but the feeling had settled deep in her bones. *But what would he do when he found out? He certainly wouldn't take it as easily as he had learning her name.* She watched the animated characters dance over the screen, trying to distract herself, trying to find a way out without losing everything she had worked so hard for.

It felt like hours had passed before she heard the door finally hiss open again, Darius stepping through quietly, his soft footsteps sounding like mini-explosions in the silence.

"Still breathing?" he asked jokingly as he approached the bed.

Myth turned her head and gave him a bright smile. "And kicking!"

He chuckled. "C'mon. Rhea messaged. There's a dinner party and we're the main guests."

She groaned dramatically. "I thought you were going to be gone forever!"

"Good," he smirked. "Means you missed me."

She stood up, stretching, brushing her hands through her hair on the way down. "I need to change. I can't go in my uniform."

He nodded. "Same. Might be nice not to wear gear to dinner."

That got a laugh from her, and she followed him into the adjacent room where clothing options had already been laid out for them. She chose a sleek black dress with iridescent threads that shimmered blue at the plunging neckline. The dress swept the floor around her ankles, and

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the folds of the cloth were decorated with dark-blue gems. It wasn't the flashiest option, but not the plainest one either. It fitted snugly around her waist, and the back was essentially non-existent, being held together with a bejewelled clasp at her neck. Darius chose a fitted, dark-blue coat with etched lapels; a subtle golden insignia was stitched into the hem. His trousers were black and velvet-styled, the sides lined with the same blue as his coat.

"You look beautiful," he breathed, coming up behind her and wrapping his arms around her tightly.

She turned and smiled up at him. "You look mighty handsome yourself."

He offered her his arm and led them back out and into the transport.

It was only a short distance to the terrace lounge that Rhea had picked. It was in the Helion Core Gardens, a bioluminescent sanctuary tucked away from the winds and prying eyes. A crystalline path wound through the garden toward the dining terrace. Light filters sparkled above the trees, making everything below look like it was dipped in a gentle dusk, while the soft sound of music flitted throughout. Myth savoured the warmth of Darius's hand on the small of her back as they came into full view of the terrace. It was a floating pavilion with white and gold columns; the tables were made of obsidian, softly lit, and suspended over a lake of luminous petals, while the water below shifted in a kaleidoscope of ripples and koi. Eira was already there to greet them, her white, frosty sheer dress flowing off a gilded bench, and her hair gently fluttering around ice-styled flowers. Her pale skin shimmered with carefully placed gems that glittered brightly in the soft light. General King stood next to her in a crisp, dark-red suit, talking animatedly with a waiter, clearly agitated. His suit was encrusted with rubies and jaspers, and he wore no shirt underneath. Instead, his chest was adorned with a golden tattoo that disappeared

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around his neck. He was motioning with a heavily ringed hand to platters of steaming delicacies and spiral glass decanters that were being placed by silver-plated drones.

As Myth and Darius approached, Rhea came into view, rising gracefully from her seat in a shimmer of dark green and living vines and flowers that curled around her skin.

“Finally!” Rhea said, giving Myth a gentle squeeze with her outstretched hand. “We’ve already ordered.”

“I don’t care if the chef’s credentials were reviewed by the Solar Chancellor himself,” King was saying smoothly, swirling a thin flute of wine between two fingers. “If the reduction separates in the atmosphere, it is, by definition, not a reduction.”

The waiter bowed and mumbled a jumble of words before speeding away.

Eira didn’t look at him as she plucked a candied seed pod delicately off a tray. “You’re going to give that poor man a nervous collapse.”

King exhaled dramatically, turning with a flourish. “Good. Let him fall into a coma and dream of proper technique.”

Rhea turned from Myth with a smile. “You know, not everyone was raised with crystal stemware and neural sommeliers.”

“Nyx, Darius. Perfect timing,” Eira greeted, turning slightly in a flurry of soft snow. “The General was just about to declare war on the sommelier-bot over the ’87 vintage Cygnus X-1.”

“It’s about **standards!**” King exclaimed, the ruby clasps on his suit catching the light brilliantly.

Darius pulled out a seat next to Rhea for Myth, settling her gently before taking a seat on the other side of her. Before Myth could get comfortable, Commander Voxx arrived, dressed in a smooth, drape-styled onyx suit that subtly concealed his wings underneath. Something about his

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look caused Myth's thoughts to stutter, something familiar. Lynx Kairen, who was dressed in steel-grey robes with heavy silver tassels and chains that swung around his waist and neck, flanked him.

"Gods, King," Voxx drawled, "you would serve fourteen-hundred-credit vintages to distract from a slightly too-cool roux."

The General laughed, his voice booming in the cosy space, clapping Voxx on the shoulder. "That's assuming the wine wasn't the plan all along. Besides," his eyes swept the table, landing on her, "we have a new Quasar to celebrate."

Voxx's gaze followed King's; his piercing platinum eyes felt like a knife through Myth's heart. She smiled, trying to ignore her mind screaming, trying to ignore the memory of perfume orchids and the same voice, younger but just as deep, murmuring low against her ear. Her hand on his jaw as he whispered to her.

She felt Darius's hand on her knee, bringing her back to the present, to Eira saying, "...which I'm sure she finds absolutely ghastly." Her icy hand waved through the air in a flurry of snow.

"Well, the Solaris-Vaelith pact is already being challenged again," Darius quipped. "They wasted no time."

"The House of Cygnus thinks they can offer Rhea a better genetic pairing," Eira huffed. "Can you imagine? Them? Their bloodline is practically diluted to artisan-grade."

Rhea's laugh held a lilt. "Lord Cygnus may be ambitious, but it seems fate is against him. I heard there were no mutations at all in his last birthing cycle."

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“He’s hoping to breed his way out of mediocrity, even approaching the House of Kairen,” Lynx snorted, undoing his coat and draping his athletic figure over a chair. Voxx seated himself next to him in a flourish, and the table was complete.

“Ambition without substance is just noise,” Voxx said, already reaching for his wine glass.

King nodded, turning to Myth. “And you, Nyx? Are you ready for the scandalous Null-lineages to hound you the way they hound our dear Eira?”

“There will be no hounding,” Darius interjected. “They hound Eira because she teases them.”

“I can’t help but toy.” Eira batted her eyes before laughing. “Besides, it’s not my fault they don’t know it’s hopeless.”

The conversation flowed easily among them after that. Lynx lamenting that the betting pools were outrageous this Apex Crucible cycle, Rhea gossiping about a minor Apex lord caught synergising with a Null, and King regaling them with his and Eira’s monster takedown. She was laughing, enjoying the sweet and savoury taste of the food that she was served. Suddenly, as Voxx’s voice echoed across the table, she felt a stab of pain lance through her head.

“Come on, Thallion!” She was calling to a young Voxx. Pale and serious, poised with his hands clasped behind his back, six strong blades of light shimmered around him.

In a flash, the memory was gone, leaving a cold feeling to rush over her. She downed her drink and blinked hard, trying to focus on the conversation.

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“Instability creates opportunity,” Voxx was stating. “Hysteria is a resource in small amounts. High Chancellor Mereen is already spinning the monster attacks into new recruitment drives.”

“All that means is that the main houses need to strengthen their alliances. Get off their laurels and actually work to retain their statuses,” Rhea added, rising from her seat and walking to the bar at the edge of the pavilion. She retrieved a vivid green drink before turning with a flourish. “Nulls, in general, need to finally merge into Dregs.”

The table murmured in agreement, and Myth nodded along, her head still aching.

The conversation swirled distantly around her as her drink settled into her bones, the warm fire of something alcoholic burning away at her nerves. The wind tickled her skin, cool and refreshing, and she stood gently, walking to the edge of the pavilion, looking over the lower gardens and elite crystal hubs below.

She felt another lance through her skull, the conversation fading in and out in a roar.

“The press is calling them ‘Fane’s Horrors’. It’s so melodramatic, but it does sound good for an Apex-level threat.” Darius’s voice cut through the fog; he had come up behind her. “Nyx?” His voice was low in her ear, his breath warm against the chill. “You good?”

She blinked hard, looking up at him. She nodded and gave him a warm smile. “I just needed to stretch my legs,” she said easily. He nodded, turning back to the conversation, but not leaving her side.

She blinked again, and suddenly she was back in the cold dark. The hard walls of the training room closed in around her as the sharp, stinging pain of energy suppressors flooded the air. Thallion stood over her, huffing in exertion, his face a web of disappointment and pain. A

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sharp voice echoed above them: “Again. The goal is to reach a baseline.” The voice echoed with a chilling sense of familiarity.

“Myth,” Darius whispered in her ear. She whirled to face him, crashing back to the present and almost knocking his drink out of his hand.

“I’m sorry. I must have drunk too much,” she murmured. Darius nodded and wrapped a warm arm around her shoulders comfortingly, turning her back to his chest. She leaned against him and observed that she at least wasn’t the only one tipsy. King and Eira were swept up in their own private conversation, passionately debating each other, their drinks sloshing in their hands with their enthusiastic flourishes. They made their way to the lower level of the pavilion, a low-hanging tree slightly obscuring them as they made their way into the lower gardens. Rhea and Lynx seemed to also be locked in conversation, but of a more intimate sort. They were wrapped in a gentle green mist, and eventually Lynx stood, swaying lightly, before pulling Rhea up with him. Voxx came up behind her and whispered something that made the emerald woman giggle before all three of them disappeared down a dimly lit path deep into the cover of the trees.

Myth turned back towards Darius, swaying slightly, the drink making her eyes fuzzy as she looked up at him. He was watching her intently with a small smile on his lips.

“Walk with me?” he asked, offering his arm to her.

She took it gratefully, leaning into his steady warmth as he led her out into the endless expanse of lush beauty. The walkways floated slightly off the ground, edged with giant glowing pearls that shimmered in the water. Pink petals drifted endlessly down, perfuming the air with a sweet scent and dropping gently on the flowing streams.

They walked slowly in the quiet, her head on Darius’s bicep as they walked.

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“You lost in thought again?” Darius asked in a murmur, slowing slightly to turn and look down at her.

Myth’s throat went dry, the drink buzzing in her head making her slow to formulate a sensible answer. “I hadn’t expected such a nice get-together.”

He didn’t speak, and Myth kept her gaze forward. “Plus, who would have thought the people who could crack the planet in half are worried about soup temperatures?”

He gave a soft laugh, turning and coming to a gentle stop. “Yeah,” he said. “I forget sometimes that not everyone grew up with this.”

She looked at him finally. “Did you?”

“Mostly,” he said, brushing a strand of hair out of her face. “The Apex schools, elite combat forces with formal table etiquette by thirteen. I knew a salad fork before I knew a friend.”

Myth nodded, resisting the urge to chew on her lip. He brought her hand to his lips and kissed her knuckles lightly, leaving a blazing trail of fire and nerves in his wake. He pulled her into his chest, his lips brushing her ear, sending shivers down her spine. “Let’s go home.”